

Guinea

 With more than 30 per cent of the world's known reserves of bauxite, and deposits of diamonds, iron, copper, manganese, uranium and gold, Guinea could be a wealthy country. However, years of poor government and lack of support from former French rulers have made Guinea's economic development difficult.



Coffee beans



Bananas



Pineapple

Fruit growing

Bananas, plantains, and pineapples grow well in the fertile Fouta Djallon hills (Guinea Highlands). Farmers cultivate coffee, palm nuts, and groundnuts as cash crops and sorghum, rice, and cassava for their families.

GUINEA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Conakry
AREA	245,860 sq km (94,926 sq miles)
POPULATION	7,400,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	French, Fulani, Malinke, Susu
MAJOR RELIGIONS	Muslim, traditional beliefs,
CURRENCY	Guinea franc



People

Three-quarters of Guineans belong to one of three main ethnic groups – the Malinke and Fulani who live in the north and centre, and the Susu who live closer to the coast. Two-thirds live in small rural communities, where the standard of living is one of the lowest in the world. Average life expectancy is low, at only 45 years, and only about 35 per cent of people can read.

Sierra Leone

 Sierra Leone was founded by the British in the early 1800s as a colony for freed slaves. Its name is Spanish for "Lion Mountains" and refers to the constant roar of thunder. Of the 12 ethnic groups, the biggest are the Mende and the Temne. A ceasefire halted civil war in 2000.

Industry

Mining is the mainstay of Sierra Leone's economy. The chief exports are diamonds, some of which are still mined by hand, as well as gold, bauxite, and titanium ore. Farming employs more than two-thirds of the work-force, growing coffee, cocoa, palm kernels, ginger, and cassava.



Uncut diamond looks like any other stone.



Freetown

Surrounded by green hills, Sierra Leone's capital, Freetown, is a colourful and historic port and home to more than 700,000 people. The name is a reminder of the country's former status as a haven for freed slaves. Among Freetown's attractions are a 500-year-old cotton tree, and West Africa's oldest university, built in 1827.

Ivory Coast

 With 600 km (370 miles) of Atlantic coastline, and three main rivers, Ivory Coast is fertile and farming efficient. It is among the world's top producers of coffee and cocoa. Food accounts for half of all exports. Most people work in farming and forestry. Nearly all the forests have been sold off as timber to pay foreign debts.

IVORY COAST FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Yamoussoukro
AREA	318,000 sq km (122,780 sq miles)
POPULATION	14,891,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	French, Akan
MAJOR RELIGIONS	Muslim, Christian, traditional beliefs
CURRENCY	CFA franc

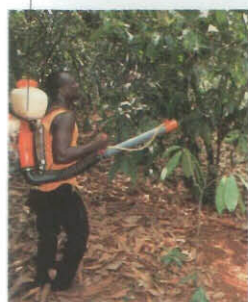


Yamoussoukro Basilica

Although only 29 per cent of the people of the population are Christian, Ivory Coast has one of the world's largest Christian churches. Able to seat 7,000 people, it dominates the city of Yamoussoukro, which replaced Abidjan as the country's capital in 1983.

Cocoa

Ivory Coast is the world's leading producer of cocoa beans. Cocoa trees need humid conditions, and many cocoa plantations lie in moist, tropical regions where rainforests were felled for timber. Factories have been set up in Ivory Coast to make cocoa butter, which is the basic ingredient of chocolate and some cosmetics.



Farmers use pesticides on cocoa plantations, but the lack of protective clothes is a serious health risk.

Liberia

 Founded by the USA in the 1820s as a home for freed black slaves, Liberia has never been colonized. About five per cent of the people descend from former slaves and American settlers. The rest are a varied mix of ethnic groups. About 70 per cent of Liberians work on the land, growing oil palms, coffee, and cocoa, and rubber for export. Civil war has damaged trade.



LIBERIA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Monrovia
AREA	96,320 sq km (37,189 sq miles)
POPULATION	3,200,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	English, Kpelle, Bassa, Vai, Grebo, Kru, Kissi, Gola
MAJOR RELIGIONS	Christian, traditional beliefs, Muslim
CURRENCY	Liberian dollar



Civil war

Since 1990, Liberia has been torn by a chaotic and bloody civil war, and its once prosperous economy has collapsed. The war, which began as clashes between various ethnic groups, has made thousands of people homeless and many are forced to live in large refugee camps where food shortages are a part of everyday life.

Monrovia

Reputedly the world's wettest capital city, with more than 4,560 mm (183 in) of rain per year, Monrovia is a sprawling city and major port. Liberia has the world's largest commercial fleet of ships. Almost all are foreign owned, but registered in Monrovia, where taxes are low.